

Battle of Kings Mountain
One of the greatest triumphs of the irregular frontier riflemen in the American Revolutionary War was their defeat of a force of well-trained Loyalist militia at Kings Mountain in 1780 *(above)*. The weapon that made them so successful as snipers and skirmishers was the long-barrelled rifle *(right)*, originally made for hunting.

EXPERT RIFLEMEN were the first companies of soldiers raised by the rebellious North American colonies to fight the British army and its Loyalist supporters at the start of the American Revolutionary War. At a time when inaccurate muskets were the standard military firearm, the accuracy of the American frontier marksmen's rifle fire inspired fear and awe. Although they were resistant to formal discipline, these tough and independent fighters proved impressively effective as sharp-shooting snipers and battlefield skirmishers.

The riflemen originated from the American frontier world of farmers and hunters – settlers carving out a life for themselves in the wild, gun in hand. Introduced to North America from Europe by German and Swiss immigrants, rifles were regarded principally as a hunting weapon. Americans developed the design of the European rifle to give it greater accuracy and range, creating what was later called the Kentucky rifle. With this long-barrelled, small-bore gun, farm boys and woodsmen learned to shoot with astonishing accuracy. They honed their skills in hunting, in skirmishes with Indians, and in shooting competitions, which became a favourite frontier pastime. Men would, for instance, compete to hit the head of a turkey – alive and moving – at a range of around 100m (330ft). Frontiersmen were also known for their hardihood and independent spirit, having learned the art of survival in virgin wilderness. They would consequently show endurance on the march and an ability to travel light, living off the land when required.



LONG RIFLE MADE IN PENNSYLVANIA IN THE 1750S

RIFLEMEN FOR THE REVOLUTION

The frontiersmen were not material from which regular soldiers could easily be made, but the leaders of the American colonies gathered in the Continental Congress were quick to recognize their military potential. Future US President John Adams expressed the opinion that they would make "an excellent species of light infantry" since they were "the most excellent marksmen in the world". Thus on 14 June 1775, Congress resolved that "six companies of expert riflemen be immediately raised in Pennsylvania, two in Maryland, and two in Virginia". The response in Pennsylvania was so enthusiastic that the state in fact provided nine companies. Volunteers initially enlisted for a year, with the promise of a gift of land to reward their services after victory. Each company typically had four officers, eight NCOs, and 68 men. Their immediate mission was to join the American forces besieging the British and Loyalists in Boston. The journey from the frontier regions to the New England coast had to be made on foot, a formidable march undertaken at a punishing rate. The riflemen from western Maryland, led by Michael Cresap, covered the 990km (550 miles) from their recruiting point to Boston in three weeks – taking time en route to stage demonstrations of their marksmanship, including, in one instance, a rifleman firing at a target held between his brother's knees.

The arrival of the frontiersmen outside Boston caused a considerable stir. Their dress immediately marked them out as wild men: they wore fringed hunting shirts, moccasins, and hats decorated with feathers or animal tails, and many carried scalping knives and tomahawks as well as their rifles. Their accurate sniper fire soon began to take its toll of British sentries around Boston and even of officers who had the temerity to show themselves in the open.